logistics units, were pumped into this theatre. The government approved the use of the air force on 25 May 1999, albeit on our side of the LoC only. For us in the military operations directorate, it was like a war, whether declared or not. We began working 24x7 since we got the first situation report from the Corps HQ at Srinagar on 8–9 May 1999. Frequently, we had to stay up all night and follow the progress of the battle. After all we were dealing with blatant aggression and a rogue action by the adversary to capture our territory. We accepted the challenge and adopted a mission mode. It was our firm determination to get the intruders out and restore the sanctity of the LoC. If it called for a hard kick on their butts, so be it.

Initially, in the second and third weeks of May 1999, we suffered quite a few setbacks. It must be admitted that our forward troops and commanders were caught off guard and their early assessments of the situation were totally off the mark. Firstly, the enemy situation was not at all clear, and secondly, pressure was being put from all directions for early action to throw the intruders out, as a result of which hasty and uncoordinated attacks without adequate artillery support were launched by our units and formations. The fog of war, coupled with total denial of any involvement by the Pakistan Army, resulted in inaccurate assessments of the aim, strength and dispositions of the intruders in the initial stage. It took us almost a week or two to get the overall picture right. Having got our act together, the strategy evolved was to obtain the details of the intrusions, contain them and systematically clear them. We laid down priorities and planned to capture the enemy positions accordingly. Features dominating Dras, like Tololing and Tiger Hill, were accorded the highest priority. However, we had to keep in mind the caveat by the government that the LoC should not be crossed. This imposed certain constraints on our operational plans as we could not isolate and cut off the enemy positions from the rear in all cases.

Waves of well-planned and coordinated infantry assaults, mostly from the flanks or rear, with overwhelming artillery support, including multi-barrel rocket launchers, and debilitating air attacks